
databricks
DATA+AI
SUMMIT
2026

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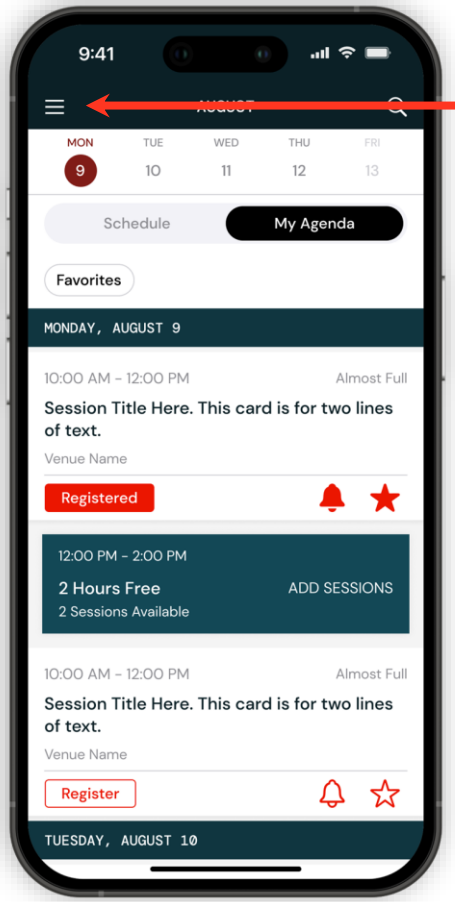
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One Platform to Replace Them All

Our Databricks migration

Curt Roehricht

Myself!

Curt Roehricht –

Data Engineering Manager at Fonterra in Ingredients and Trading Data and Analytics



Fonterra and I&T - Who Are We?



Our co-op

We are a dairy Co-operative, owned and supplied by thousands of farming families in Aotearoa New Zealand. Through the spirit of co-operation and a can-do attitude, we share the goodness of milk with customers in more than 100 countries around the world, from our home base here in New Zealand. We believe that food and nutrition are essential to sustain us today and for future generations to thrive. This is why we take great care with every drop of milk, from farm through to customer.



Fonterra's operations

Fonterra provides high-quality dairy products to more than 100 countries globally through our Ingredients, Foodservice and Consumer sales channels.

In FY25, these channels generated more than $26 billion in revenue.

The data shown on this page reflects Fonterra's Total Group operations, including the Mainland Group (Consumer and associated businesses) proposed to be divested.

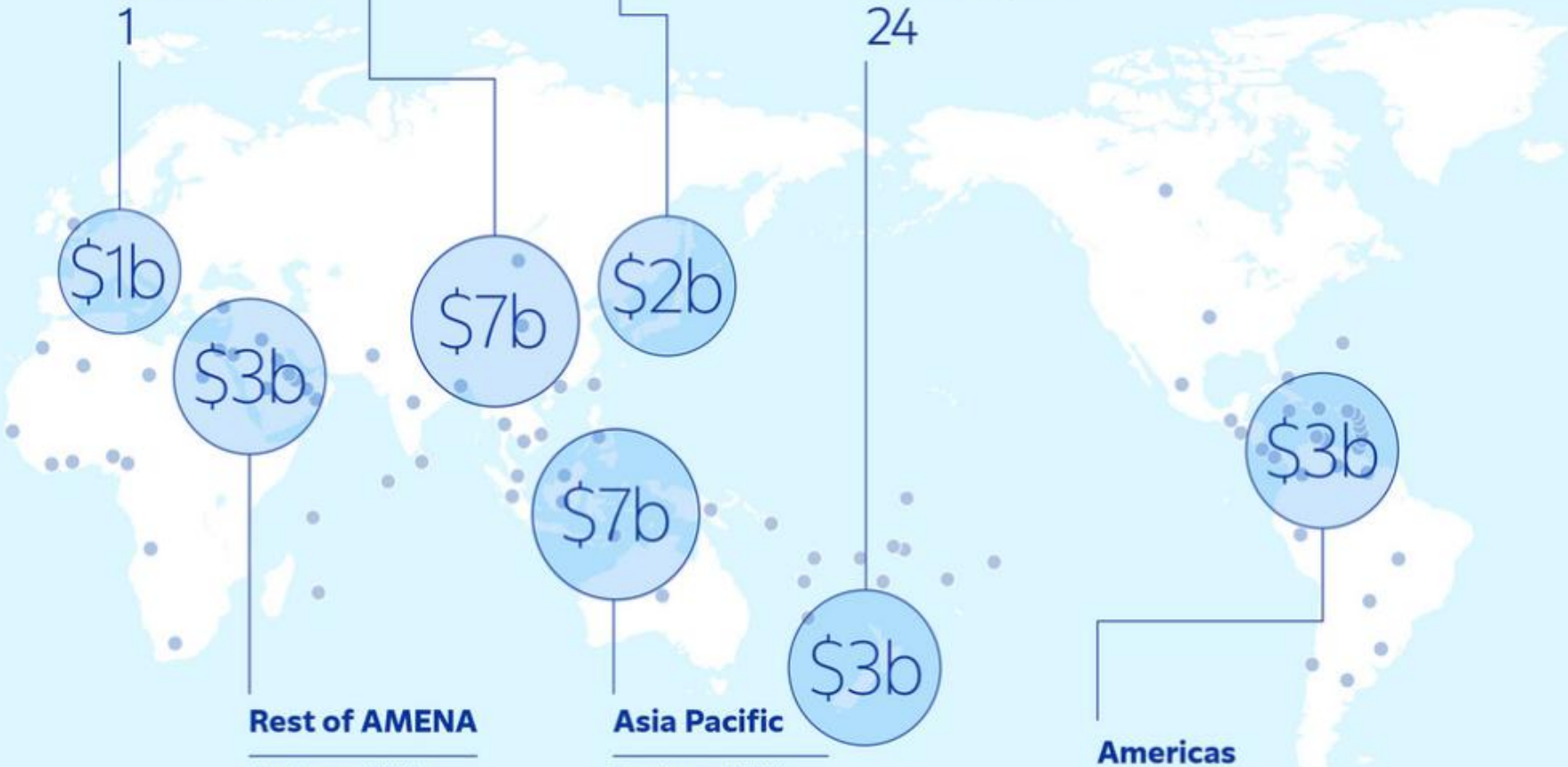
Revenue (NZD)

~26b

Employees (FTE)[1]

~15,700

1 Employee figures only include permanent employees. Figures presented have been rounded.



Europe

Employees (FTE)

130

Manufacturing sites

1

China

Employees (FTE)

640

North Asia

Employees (FTE)

100

New Zealand

Employees (FTE)

11,570

Manufacturing sites

24

Markets we export to

Rest of AMENA

Employees (FTE)

210

Manufacturing sites

1

Asia Pacific

Employees (FTE)

2,930

Manufacturing sites

12

Americas

Employees (FTE)

100

Ingredients & Trading

Ingredients & Trading is Fonterra's value engine — transforming milk into high-value ingredients and using trading expertise to deliver the greatest possible return from every drop. We continuously decide what to make and where to sell it by combining market signals, customer demand, pricing and risk insights, so milk flows into the products and channels that create the most value



Where We Come From



The Market analytics system (MAS) – Legacy platform

A platform designed to support both reporting and business applications across Fonterra. It was made up of four major components and various minor components:

Snaffler

- Custom bespoke data extractor
- 130+ source profiles

SSIS

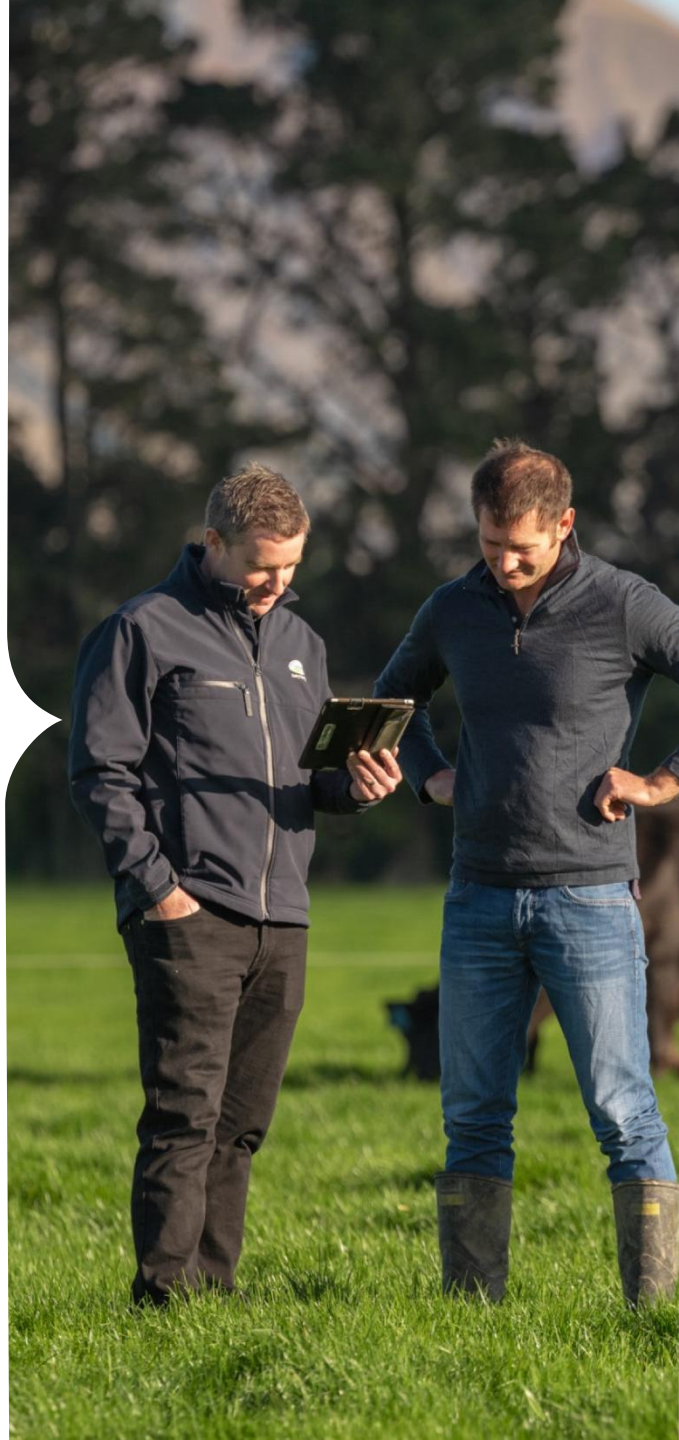
- Transformation layer to take snaffler outputs and transform within the database

SQL Server

- On premise 2019 server
- 300+ tables across multiple databases

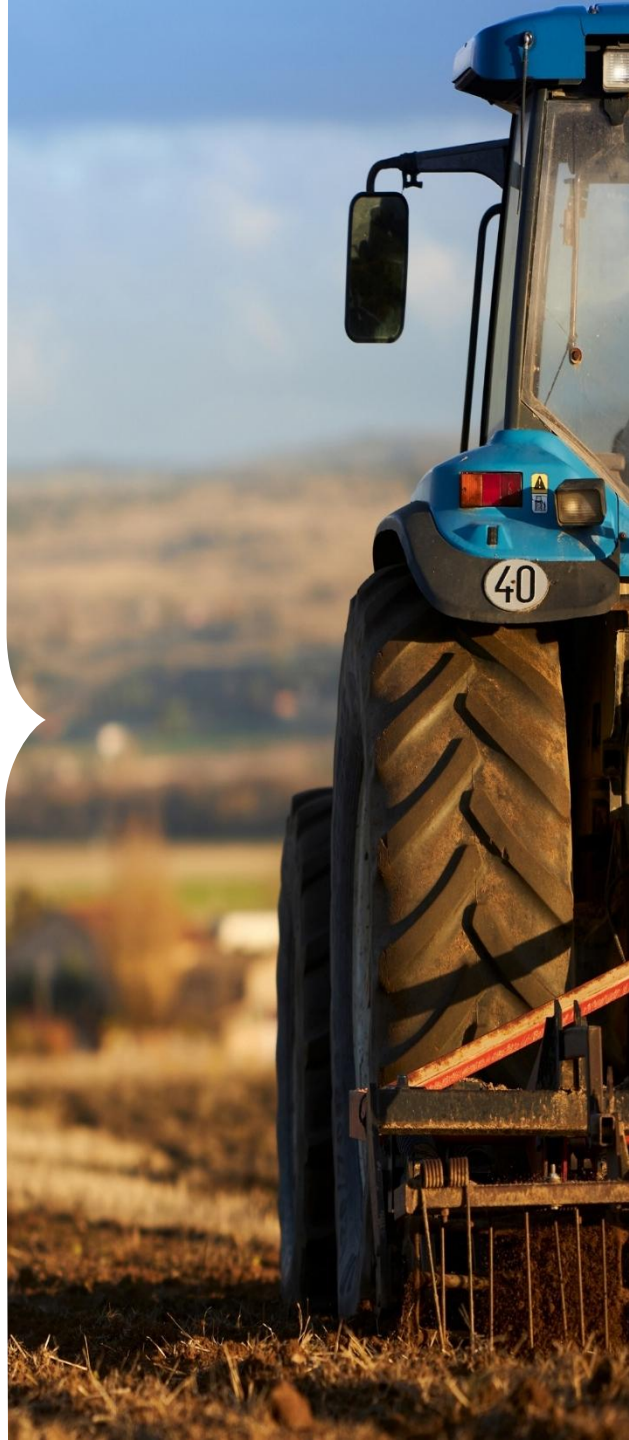
PowerBI/Fabric

- Reports Dashboards apps



MAS – The challenges

- Disjointed daisy chain architecture multiple points of failure.
- BAU overhead roughly 50% of teams capacity allocated to support.
- Scaling limitations.
- Server maintenance, backups and patching overhead.
- Little governance or data quality applied.
- Hard coded configs.
- Difficult to onboard and train new engineers.
- Very little documentation – critical dependency on original contractors.
- Using tools that were outside of support.
- Code and ML models living on peoples laptops.
- Etc.



Where we are



Key milestones

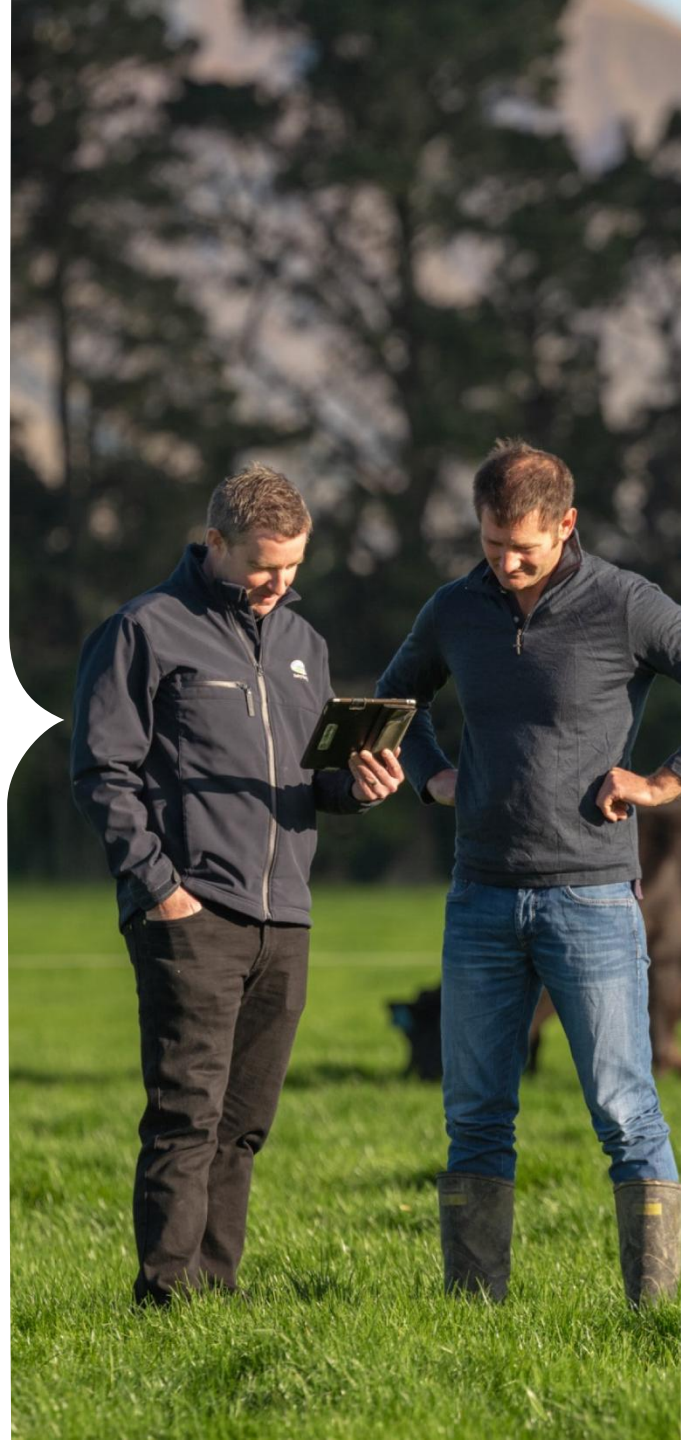
Early 2024 an assessment of the MAS platform was undertaken

Late 2024 a project was started to scope out decommissioning of MAS and selecting the replacement platform

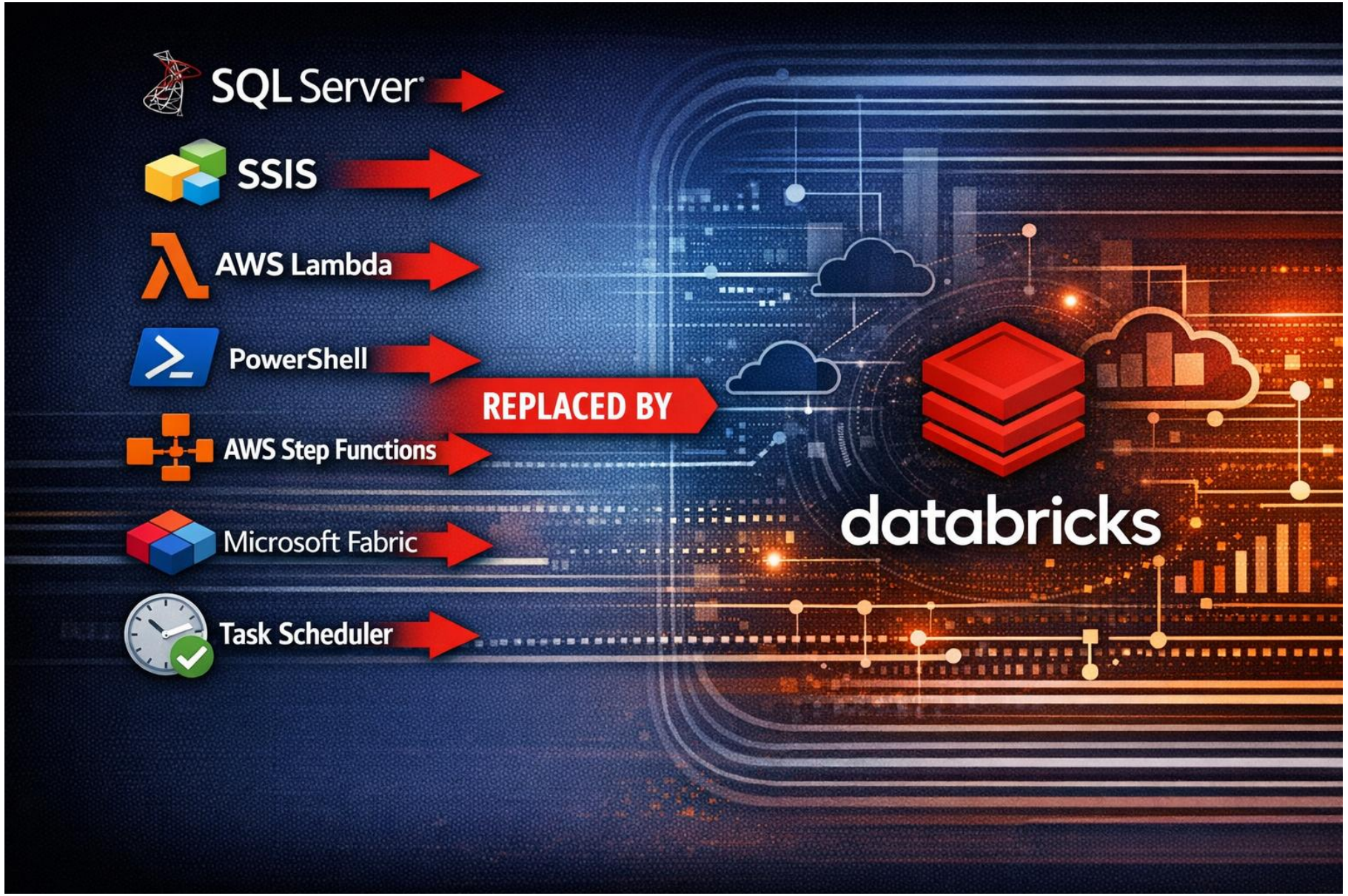
In early 2025 the project was kicked off to start moving the whole MAS system inside of Databricks

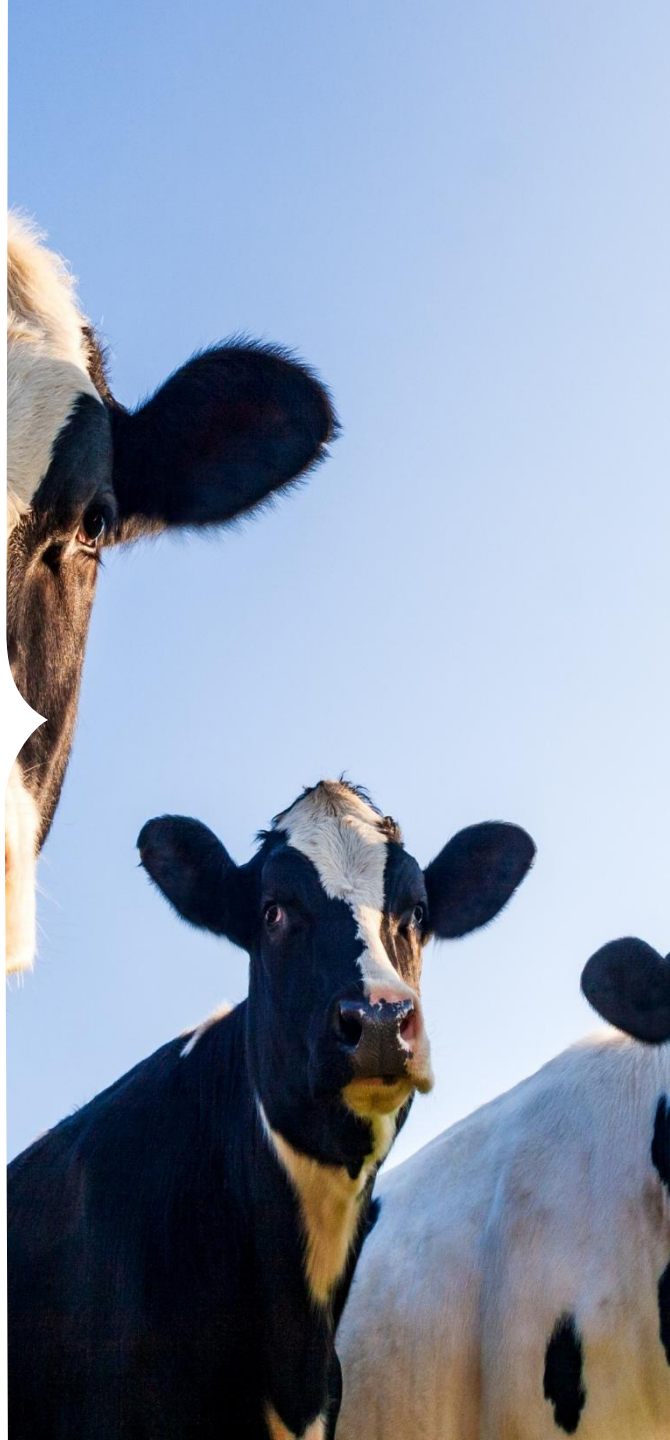
Mid 2026 MAS was nearly completely decommissioned

Current state, Databricks is now the agreed data platform to source and ingest data and all required MAS data is now in Databricks.



The outcome


SQL Server
SSIS
AWS Lambda
PowerShell
REPLACED BY
AWS Step Functions
Microsoft Fabric
Task Scheduler
databricks



What that means

BAU and bug fixes reduced to less than 20% across less resources and declining.

No longer require external parties to help support and maintain infrastructure which leads to reduced costs.

Data is easier to find and all inside of the unity catalogue with lineage.

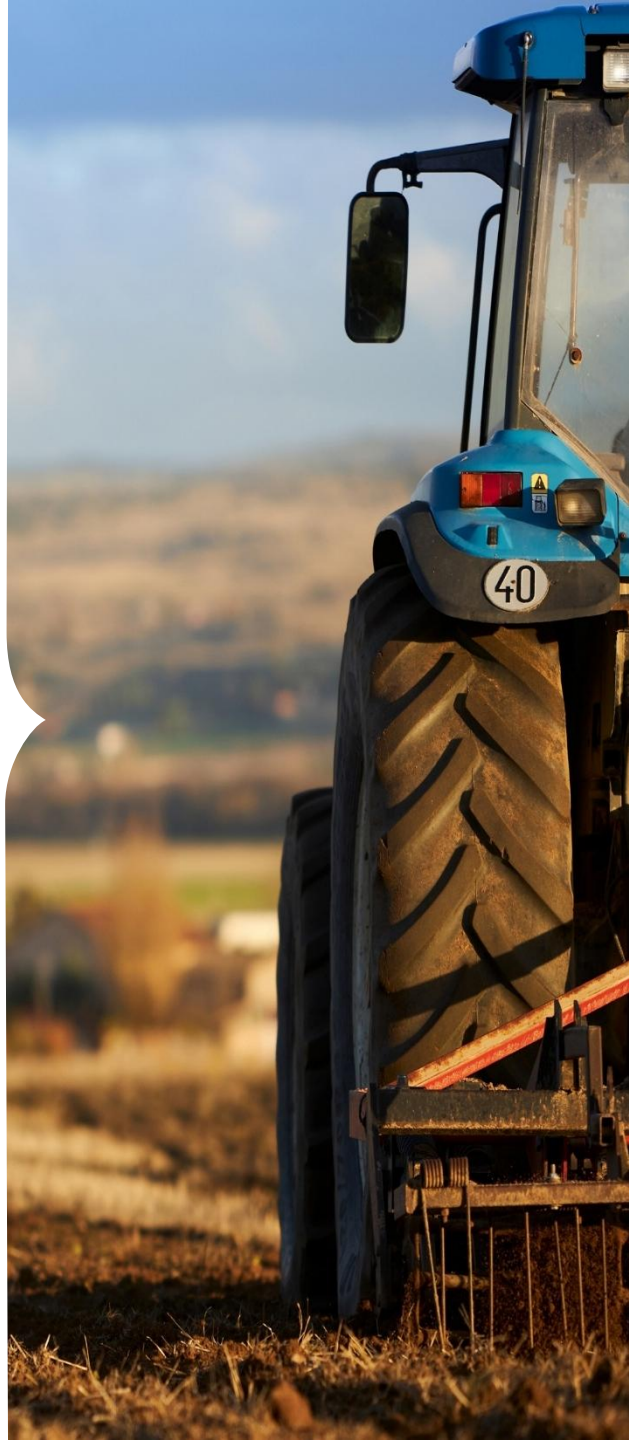
9 integration points down to 2. Reduced points of failure.

Easy deployments and releases through data asset bundles. Ability for daily releases if needed.

Projects delivery time reduced on average from months to weeks(even days in some cases).

Ability to now delta share both receiving and sending making sharing data so much quicker and easier.

Engaged and excited engineers.



Meanwhile the rest of Fonterra



Introducing the SharePoint Insights Agent

Whether you're a site owner, or a site member, Co-op GPT gives you quick access to SharePoint Insights in one central place.



Organisation wide genie

SharePoint Insights Genie

The agent gives you quick insight sharepoint sites you own or are a member of

These insights can help you understand ownership gaps, retention and usage, so you can manage your sites in a compliant and effective way.

How it is used:

- Users can now simply ask:
- What is the retention period for [SITE]?
- Of the Teams or SharePoint sites I own, which ones need a second owner?
- Which Teams or SharePoint sites I own are inactive or rarely used?
- Do I own any SharePoint sites that could be deleted?

Real use case examples:

“reduce the sprawl of ever growing sharepoints sites.”

With Genie:

- Ability to see trends on site creation
- Manage the health of share point sites
- Easy access to the meta information to make call to actions
- Provide recommendations based on metadata
- Unexpected Benefits

Strategic Impact:

Shifting SharePoint from an undermanaged platform to a well-governed application — with lower cost oversight and an optimised site footprint

Where We Are - In Action(I&T)



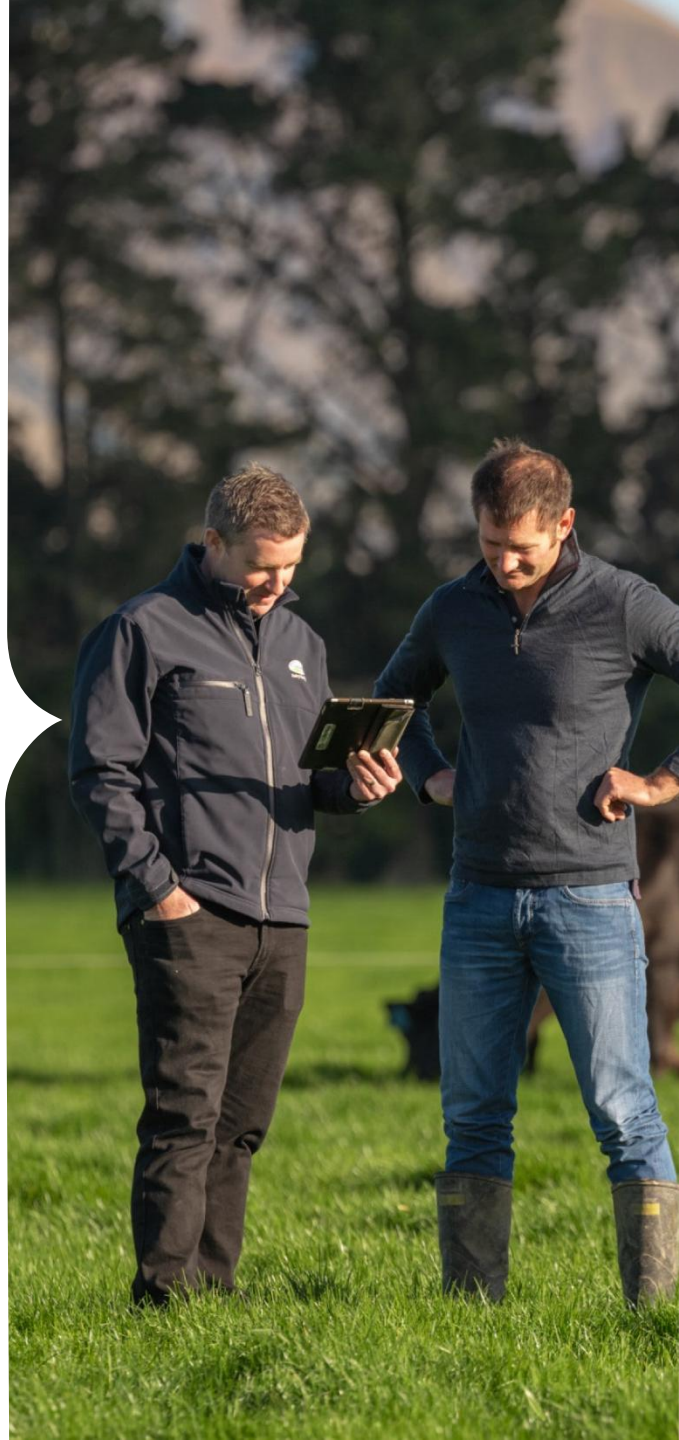
Issues we were trying to solve with Genie Spaces

The generic problems we were trying to solve:

- Difficult to Locate the right dataset
- Write or adapt SQL / Excel / Power BI queries
- Export results
- Manually build charts
- Interpret results
- Write commentary

With Genie Spaces:

- Ask the question in natural language
- Instantly explore visuals and data
- See key insights highlighted
- Review draft commentary
- Re-use generated SQL if needed
- **Fast, thorough, and repeatable analysis**



Our first use cases

Milk Supply forecast

What is it: A way to diagnose and evaluate milk supply forecasting.

How it is used:

- interrogate actuals at different levels of grain
- evaluate forecast accuracy at different levels of grain
- diagnose forecast errors (when where why)
- Attribute errors to environmental drivers
- evaluate ensemble models
- Generate Visualizations and commentary to report on

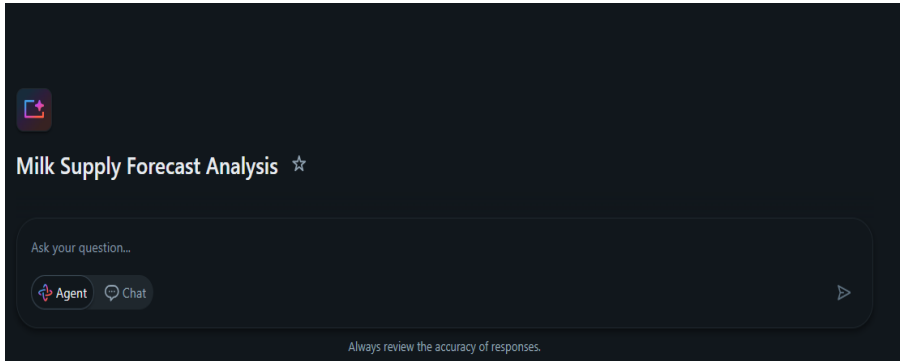
Real use case examples:

“I needed composition by season and region.”

Previously required exporting data then manipulating that data in Excel and reporting in Power BI

With Genie:

- Data returned in minutes
- Visuals tested quickly
- Hidden insights surfaced automatically
- Commentary drafted
- SQL generated for reuse



Our first use cases

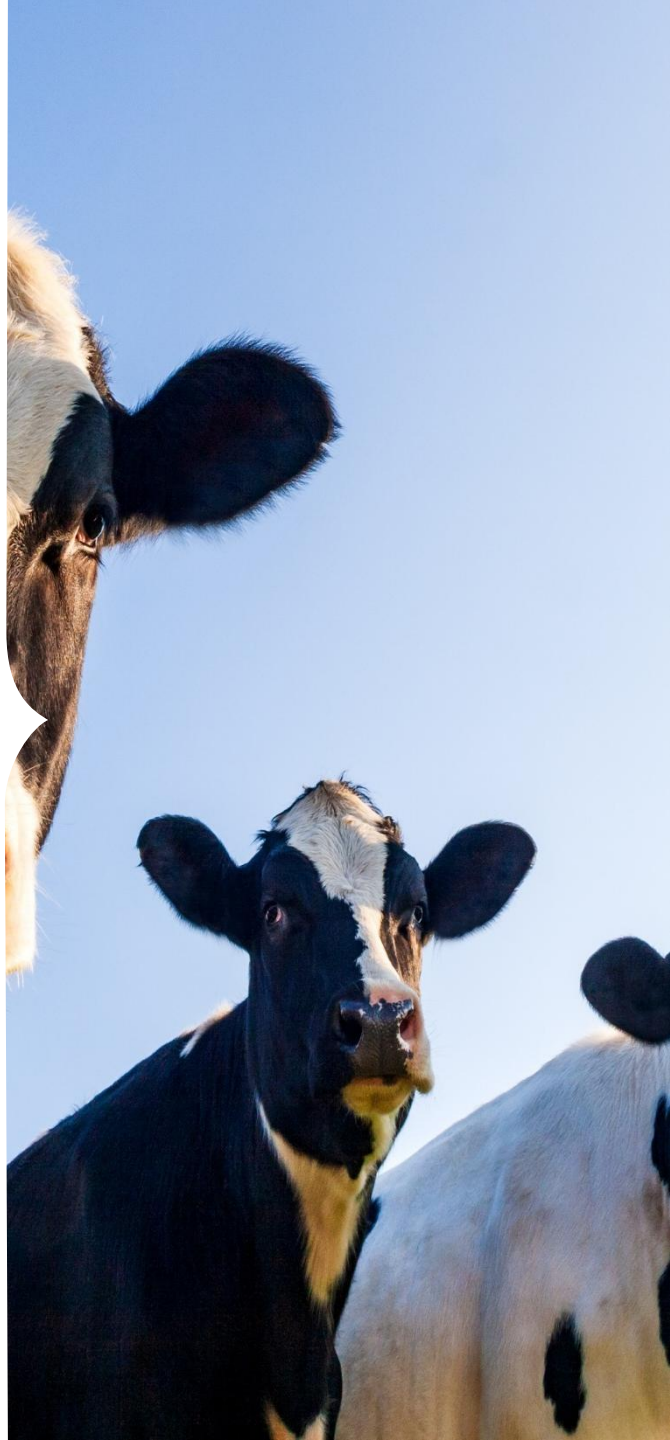
Pricing forecast analysis:

What is it: evaluate and compare accuracy of price forecast

Real use case examples:
“We release a weekly forecast to multiple stakeholders.”
Previously a very manual process to gather data and model results, put into powerpoint narrate it and then send out

How its used:
- Compare model based forecast against subject matter experts and benchmark forecasts
- Analyse forecast by product, method, horizon
- Generate Visualizations and commentary to report on
- Complete technical analysis on key drivers

With Genie:
- Compare week-on-week / month-on-month changes
- Summarize and narrate key movements
- Quantify degree of change for different time horizons
- Bust myths and preconceptions
- Generate visualisations



User-Led Wins with Genie Spaces

Genie is my new best friend at work

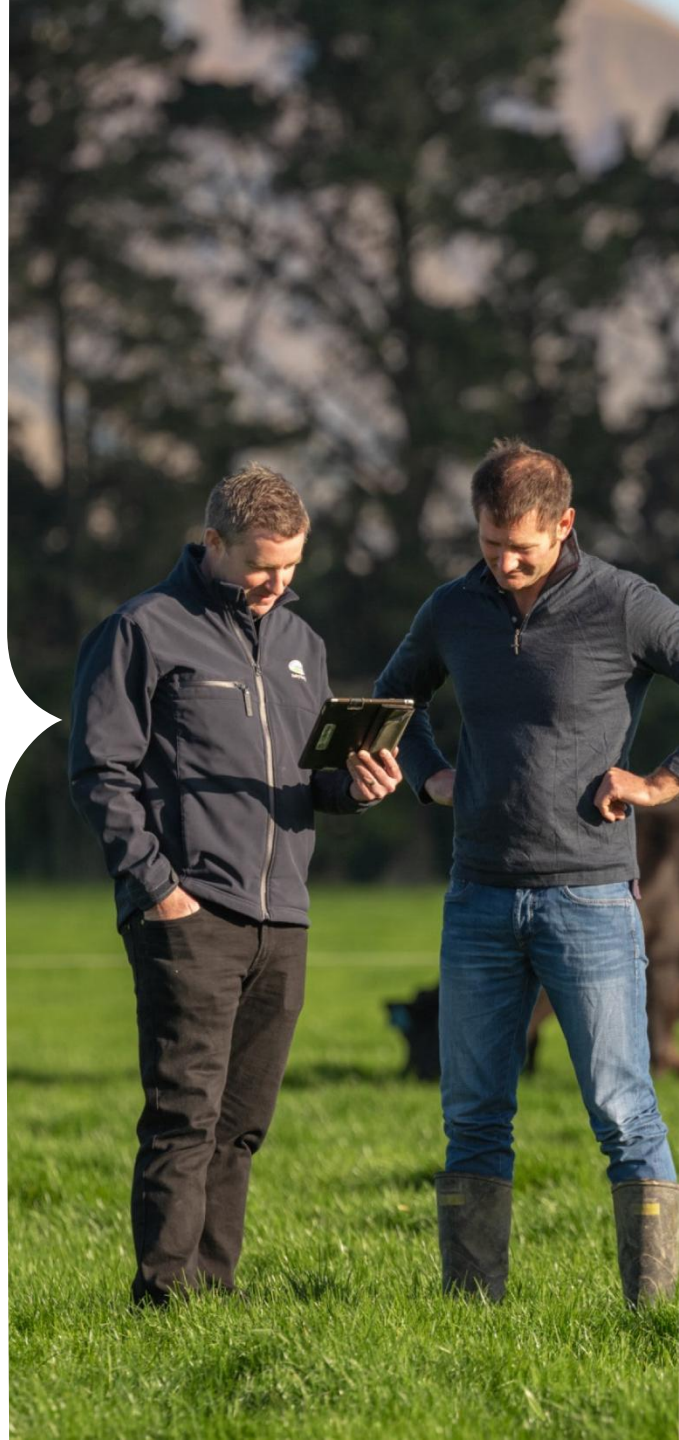
It removes friction between curiosity and insight

With Genie, within a few mins, had the data I needed, tested visuals, had some generic commentary to review before release, it picked up insights that weren't initially obvious on review of the tables

Supports ad hoc analysis

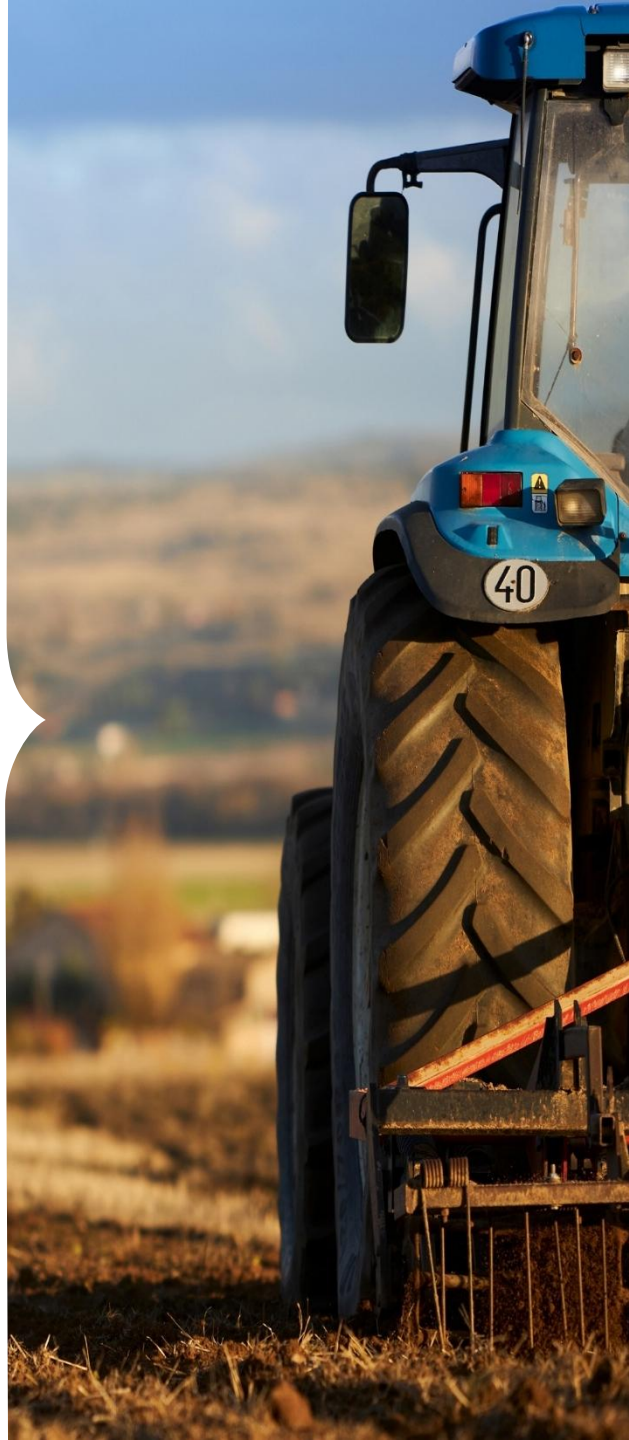
Prepares sound base commentary to communicate insights clearly

*Supply Demand and Insights team



Some key learnings/principles

- Target specific use cases
- Co-design alongside the business users (consumers)/let the users drive the evals
- Get it to the user as soon as possible to allow us to iterate and enhance
- Acknowledge that there is potential for misinterpretation. Work to minimize as much as possible
- Leverage some of the great work already done by other teams within Fonterra
- Monitor usage to make sure that it is meeting the needs. If not, go back to the drawing board



Where We Are Heading



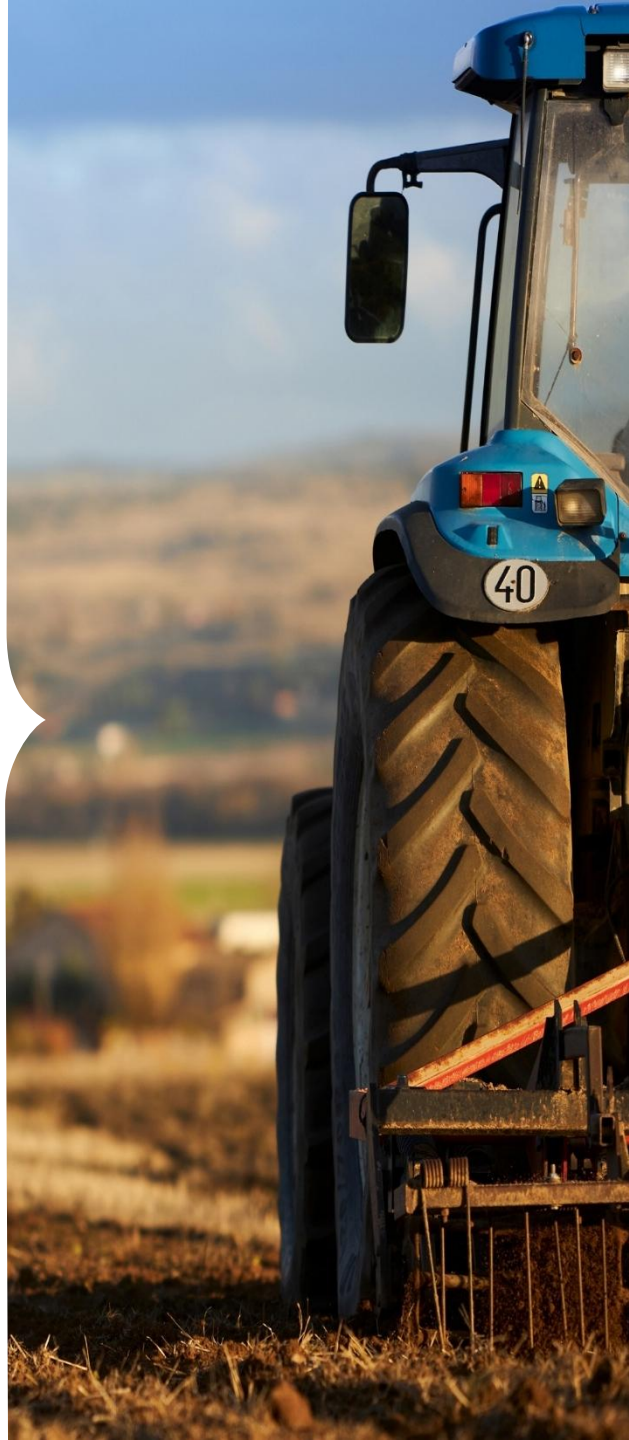
Pillar 1: Data engineering and visualisation

Adding more and more genie spaces and starting to plug these genie spaces into a supervisor agents so users have even simpler experiences.

Constantly loading more data sources, investigating Spark Declarative pipelines, Slowly converting sources to Delta shares.

Investigating the possibility of moving logic out of Fabric into Metric views

and of course… All the agents

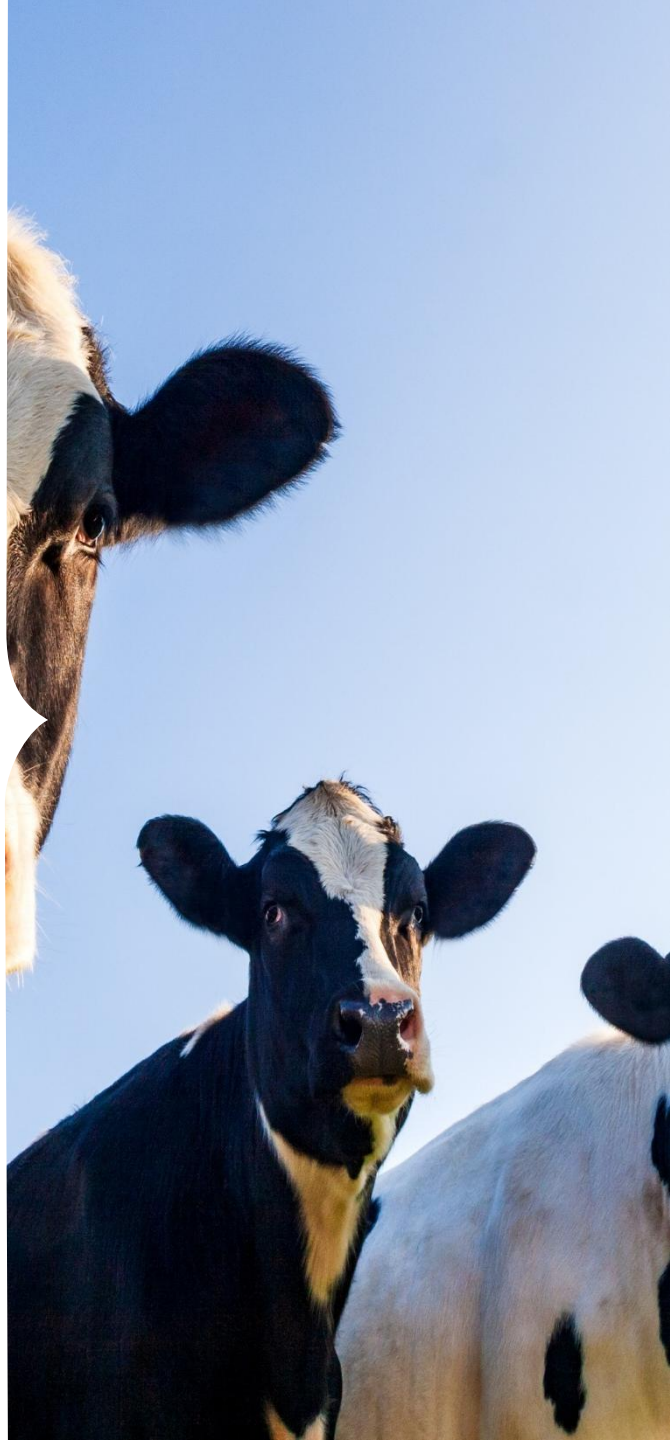


Pillar 2: Trading applications

As part of I&TDA we build and support lightweight applications for the traders however they have a large roadmap of enhancements and new applications they want built. In our current setup we can't keep up with the scale of these apps as such we are investigating a couple of options

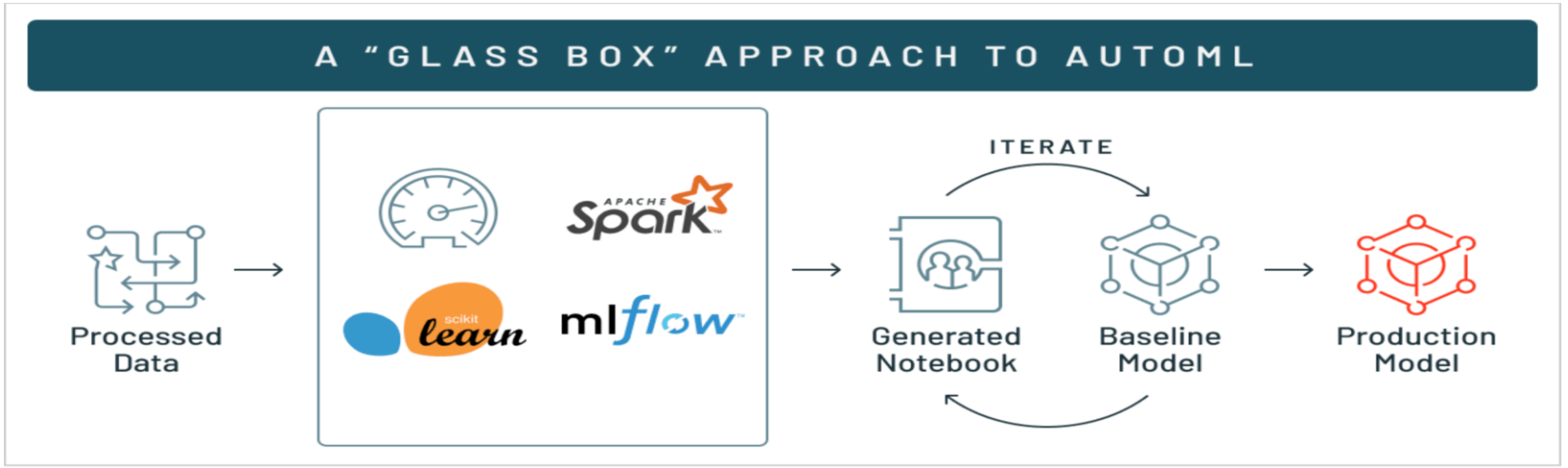
Lakebase

- Moving most of the heavy lifting to Databricks
- Migrating some of the applications to run inside of Databricks
- Using lakebase rather than sending to a separate postgress database



Pillar 3: Data science and ML

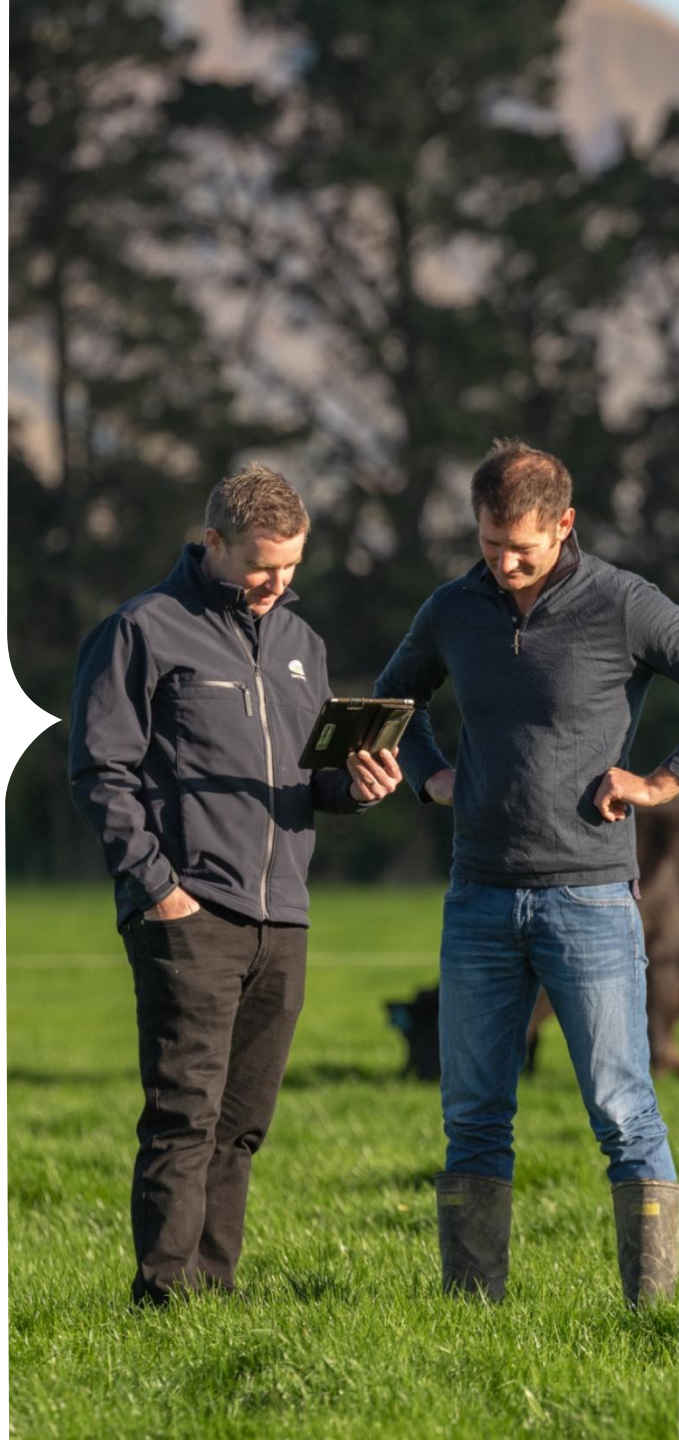
An integral part of all our outputs involves the ML work we are doing



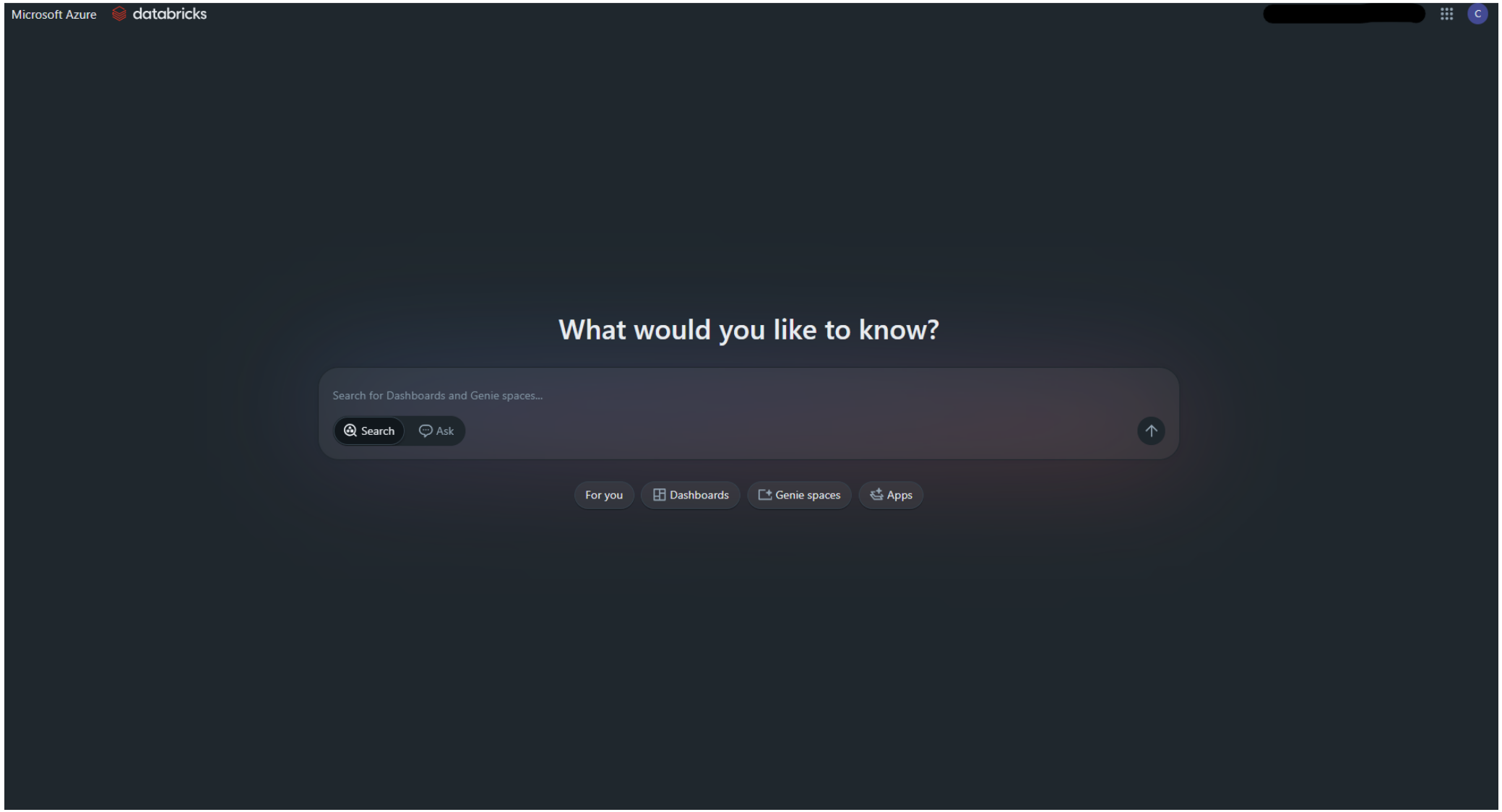
All models migrated and running in MLFlow (new models are already being built using MLFlow).

Using AI/BI Dashboards or Genie spaces to expose model results.

Vibe coding model accelerators. To help us keep up with the demand.



Our end goal?


Microsoft Azure
databricks
What would you like to know?
Search for Dashboards and Genie spaces...
Search
Ask
For you
Dashboards
Genie spaces
Apps

The team!



Huw Gibbon -
Head of Data Enablement



Matthew Hillary -
Solution Architect



Divya Perumal -
Senior Data Engineer



Ivana Franca Little-
Data Engineer



Chris Hofsteede -
Data Scientist



Nidhi Patal -
Data Engineer



Jason Cheng -
Data Engineer



James Gilmour-Hay -
Business Analyst



Peter Guo -
Visualizations Manager

Thank you

Ngā mihi